

TOO MANY BODIES

02/2026

This is the 72nd story concerning the life and career of Senior Detective Joseph Lind and his junior partner Detective Angelica ‘Angie’ De Longo. Detective Lind has been the senior statesperson on the Murder Squad floor for some time and according to some of his colleagues on the floor, age was catching up with him and if they were he, they would be considering retirement soon...very soon.

For some time, his junior partner had been attempting...encouraging her senior partner to begin placing his experiences on his personal laptop. Something to while away the hours of retirement which may result in a successful book ‘deal’...her attitude was if you never try, you will never know...

Precis:

During a period of reminiscing, Detective Lind reveals to his junior partner two homicide Cases that have stuck with him through the years. Both, he apologetically adds would be lucky to fill ten A4 pages between the two.

Not bulky material for that Great Australian Crime Novel!

The first, a homicide case of forty years ago that remained with him because of its suddenness, brutality, and senselessness. The second because the Magistrate dismissed all charges against the man and it was the closing statement of her summation that had remained with Detective Lind for most of his career.

The two Detectives are called to a murder scene where a body is discovered lying in an open stormwater drain. At first considered a homeless person who came to an untimely and accidental death. After careful examination, the manner of the man's death reminiscent of that Case he had recently disclosed to his partner.

In searching for answers, the two uncover more murders culminating in a siege situation occurring at a farmhouse in the New England high country belonging to a former felon and cellmate of their Number One suspect.

SENIOR DETECTIVE GRADE
FOUR
JOSEPH LIND
AND
DETECTIVE 2 ANGELICA ‘ANGIE’
DE LONGO

**TOO
MANY
BODIES**

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gain access to it, we suggest you demand an immediate refund and report the transaction to the author and obooko.

CHAPTER ONE

It happened at times when there was not a case to investigate. My desk clear of any Murder Books...my mind free of any Homicide Cases. As rare as these instances were, those periods of inertia were worse than having three or four homicide cases where we juggled our time to solve them and twenty-four hours in a day was never enough!

Looking busy when you are not an art form that few have managed successfully.

Most of the Dees on the floor when exposed to these conditions, spent inordinate amounts of time in some 'hidey-hole' coffee joint slowly sipping on java or alternatively, requesting old 'Cold Case' investigations from the Records Repository; to slowly sift through the facts of a particular case...surprisingly, suffering from paper cuts and nothing more! Sometimes we would crack it usually with modern DNA techniques and not

good old-fashion shoe leather; other times the records would be returned to Central Registry to remain unsolved. Gathering further layers of fine dust on the outside of their registry boxes. Other times we would take over Cases from the night shift detectives who always had more Cases than they could manage...no such luck on this occasion so it seemed!

So it was, we found ourselves sitting at one of my favourite places...the Manly Promenade licking on a two-tiered ice-cream as we watched young surfers carve up the medium-sized waves with larger sets coming through every seven or eight waves. A tempo that rarely changed throughout time. Sitting at the northern end of Manly Beach better known as Freshwater to be precise, where I had spent many an enjoyable hour doing the same thing myself as a young grummet and as a paunchy, middle-aged surfer who had problems with vertigo. The paunch becoming more noticeable in the tight steamer uniform.

I had to think when I had my last surf...a dozen years ago, I suspected. My four surfboards taken over for a time by my three daughters who wore them out...or sold them!

It was the beginning of Autumn, and you could feel the freshness in the air, especially in the early morning. My

young partner Detective ‘Angie’ De Longo broke my thoughts.

“Have you ever thought about writing down all your experiences...good and bad...and make a novel or two out of those memories?”

“Yank ex-coppers or detectives have done it before. Ed McBain comes to mind...I’ve read most of his books...enjoyable if a little laughable at times on the way the Law is seen and practiced over there...I cannot say how many he has written but I guess he has made a motza what with film rights and book sales...he was the driving force...the Technical Advisor behind one of those American cop shows back in the eighties...he would be dead now. A lot of good those hours sitting in front of a computer did him...”

“Yes...but have you ever thought of doing it?” She insisted. “You know, you must have so many stories stored in that brain of yours that you could write down for posterity...”

I had to think about it.

Sure, I was the elder statesman on the Squad floor. The oldest...no...I should say the most senior Dee in the Murder Squad. I had a protracted career spanning over forty...forty-five years...forty-six years to be precise as a Homicide Dee...the earlier years as an undercover

cop that ended in me being confined to a desk. There were too many Cases for me to remember them all and that's too many bodies for one bloke to witness was my mantra!

Far too many bodies...

I shook my head, chuckled at the memories. Many forgotten which was just as well...

"I hardly remember one or two..." Excusing my bad memory.

"Well...you can start with them." Angie was trying to be supportive. All she was doing was unconsciously causing my anxiety levels to rise because of my bad memory hitting me square in the forehead!

"Hah! Yeah...um...a bloke...in his mid-forties from memory...no, he was younger at the time. Had affiliations with one of the illegal Motorbike gangs from memory. The Tainted Angels...or was it the White Skulls...it doesn't matter, I guess. He was in one of the large parking areas of one of those...you know...those Northfield Shopping Centres..."

"Westfields..." Angie corrected softly.

"Yeah...whatever..." I did not enjoy her interruptions. "Whose telling this story?" I reprimanded, mostly

tongue-in-cheek. She held up an arm in apology. A smile to go with it.

“Yeah...well...vacant parking bays are always at a premium in those large Shopping Centres parking areas. As luck would have it, he spied an elderly couple pushing a shopping trolley walking slowly from one of the side entrances of the Centre out into the parking area. He watched their slow advance, eventually stopping at a vehicle near to where he was propped. He slowly drove down to be close to their position, propped, and waited. Unbeknown to him, a young woman had also tracked the elderly couple, and she propped further along the driveway behind our chap...”

I paused to have a chuckle and to shake my head picturing the events in my mind. It was over thirty years ago that the incident occurred, but it was a vivid memory...

“I think it could have been our fastest arrest and charge Homicide Case ever...yeah...the fastest...the guy had to be livid sitting in his 4WD watching as this elderly couple took their time transferring their weekly shopping needs from the shopping trolley into the boot of their car. Carefully stacking them so they did not slide everywhere...he would be infuriated as he watched the old bloke return the shopping trolley to the

holding chute and limp back to his vehicle with the aid of a walking cane...slowly...”

I licked my lips as talking so much had dried my lips. I asked Angie to fetch us liquid refreshments as my throat was dry...it was her turn to shout! I waited until she returned; a steaming hot coffee of quality for me and an iced tea for herself.

“Go on...” She urged. “I am listening...the bloke was becoming livid watching the slow progress of the elderly couple...in walking to their vehicle and unpacking their groceries from the trolley into the boot of the vehicle...”

I took a couple of sips of my coffee...

“Hah! Yeah...” I shook my head. Took a sip of the coffee. “You could almost see the steam clouding up the cabin of the chap’s large 4WD as the old bloke crawled in reverse out of the parking bay. The bloke slipped his vehicle into ‘Drive’ ready to occupy the vacated parking lot...a small Hatchback zoomed past him, screeching into the recently vacated parking position. Beautifully timed it was.” I chuckled remembering the action that I had reviewed countless times on the Shopping Centre security camera feeds. “The bloke in the large 4WD became infuriated, slamming his fist against the steering wheel several times before flinging open his door to march angrily

towards the small Hatchback. He shouted into the face of the young driver as she alighted, flinging his arms about. She replied flatly that as an old bloke, he was too slow and she was going to be late for work, so she was not hanging around. That was the last straw as he pulled out a handgun from his pants belt at the small of his back and shot her at point-blank range...three times in the chest...bam, bam, bam. She slumped to the ground dropping her keys in the process. The bloke straightened out the body and rolled it under the adjacent vehicle...one of those huge Yank beasts...a dual cab, V8 monster Ute with plenty of clearance...”

I took a sip of coffee after which I slowly shook my head. Again, I chuckled.

“We will never know for sure whether the chap was oblivious to the three separate security cameras in different spots around the parking area or he just forgot they were there...but an on-duty Security Officer attached to the Shopping Centre was viewing the entire episode on a wall of monitors in the Management Centre offices as the incident unfolded. Zooming into the area to obtain a better view. After the Bondi Junction stabbing murders of a couple of years back, all Shopping Centres were legislated to have a direct contact emergency line with the Police HQ. As soon as the Officer saw the muzzle flashes from the bloke’s handgun, he immediately contacted us...they had

excellent video grade, but it wasn't with sound connected to the images. We were there within eight minutes as the Centre was only blocks from our offices..."

I watched as a young 'nipper' caught a wave twice his size which he executed with speed, grace, and expertise...a ride of a lifetime.

"He will be a world champion within ten years..." I muttered to Angie, jutting my chin in the direction of the surf. She had missed the entire style and grace of the kid...the ride of the century. I was hoping some-one had caught it even on their mobile phone to give it to the young kid...if they did the boy would treasure the images for the rest of his life. The ride indelibly burnt into his young brain.

"Mmm...yeah...we were shown the body of the young woman and given a brief overview of what had transpired. We were then shown into the room where a wall of monitors were recording every corner of the Shopping Centre...inside and out in real time. The Security Officer had placed the three 'feeds' onto a larger screen on the adjacent wall. We sat and reviewed the images several times. We then switched back to the wall of monitors to watch as the suspect's movements were recorded. He seemed not to be concerned about his brutal act performed in a fit of anger. When he had

finished in the Supermarket, he sat at a nearby coffee joint to enjoy a coffee...would you believe!? He seemed unaware of the frequent passing of Shopping Centre Security Officers or the security cameras watching his every move. After consultations with the Centre Management team and now several other Murder Squad Officers, we decided against trying to take out the guy inside the Centre. Too many people about with too great a risk of collateral damage with some-one being injured or killed by a stray bullet. He had shown he was not averse to using the handgun he still had on his person. We chose to arrest the man while he was unloading his groceries into his vehicle... his hands full...his mind elsewhere.”

I stood, my throat parched.

“I am going to get a bottle of cold water as the coffee is not helping much...my throat is as dry as a goanna’s belly...do you want one?” I asked my junior partner.

She shook her head no.

Once I had returned and sat beside Angie, I took up the narration again.

“We made a terrible decision in removing the young woman’s body. If the bloke had noticed, the game would be up and he would know it. That, we felt later could only lead to one thing...a bloody shoot-out! But

the cruel bastard never even glanced in that direction which showed how cold-hearted the man was. When he returned to his vehicle to unload the shopping he had purchased, we waited until he had both hands full as he heaved the shopping bags into the rear of his 4WD. That's when we pounced with one of my fellow Dees taking the man's handgun as I instructed him to relax and show us his hands...the same old story. He tensed so I hit him on the head with the butt of my Glock. He went down like the bag of shit he was, shouting expletives loud enough for Christ to hear...but he gave us his hands for us to handcuff him." I harrumphed at the memory.

I shook my head and imbibed in the chilly water that was better on my throat. I 'arrhed' as the chilled water did wonders on its way down.

"Hah! He tried to dismantle the cell we had him in the sub-basement area without much success except for him exuding pints of sweat! We learnt the guy was driving under an assumed name and after we had formally charged him, we did an ID check on the man. He had four warrants out against him...one for the bashing murder of an opponent Bikie member in a pub brawl; another for a suspected drive-by shooting of the home of an opponent Bikie member; another for possession of illegal drugs and in possession of an illegal fire-arm with the last a failure to appear in Court

on the possession charges...a nice bloke all round, eh? When the Case hit the Court, he was sentenced to twenty-one years jail with a no non-parole period given as he had misbehaved while awaiting trial. He was ordered to attend several Anger Management Programs while incarcerated...I do not think he ever did attend any programs while there...he would be out by now...possibly a broken old man who had a 'knee-cap injury' inflicted by a fellow inmate while caged up which affects his mobility now, so I have been told...I have no idea now who told me that and even if there is a modicum of truth in the whisper..." I shook my head. "Serves the bastard right, eh?" I chuckled again after which I finished off the bottle of water.

"There you go..." Angie concluded. "A good story to start off with..."

"Umm...Ang? It would be lucky to fill five pages, a long way short of a three-hundred-page novel..." I countered with a harrumph. "I doubt I would ever be able to write such a tome..."

"Joe! Joe! You gotta start somewhere..." She stated firmly.

"Yeah...I guess. There is one other Case that has always stayed with me...about fifteen years ago..."

“Before you begin Joe, my shout for two bottles of water...”

“Gawd...you will have me peeing all bloody night!” I complained comically as I held my nether region. As she sat beside me again handing me a fresh bottle of chilled water, she earnestly looked at me.

“You don’t remember the longer ones, do you? This one you are about to tell me about...it is another short one, huh?” I nodded.

“Longer ones...ones that involve major investigations with multiple suspects and plenty of clues...or not...I do not remember the ins and outs of those Cases...would you like me to tell you this one? It is brief...”

“Yeah...no...go ahead...”

“Shelley...Shelley Shields...I am sure she was my partner during this incident. You have met Shelley...haven’t you?”

“Yes...several times. A nice lady. I have been out to her place numerous times when I have been invited to notable events...like one of your birthdays which either Tellie your wife, Shelley or Marge Hendricks usually hosted. Sometimes it was just a ‘get-together’ for a BBQ ...you know, nothing special. I think I have met all your delta lady partners, Joe, at times like that. All

clever women...and there is that same similarity between them all...you attract the same type of woman...that includes me as well, I guess.”

“You’re tarred with the same brush, Angie. You just need a little more experience to be compared with all of them...but I am confident you will get there...”

“Yeah, right. Come on, tell me this story before you forget it, huh?”

“Okay...Shelley and I were up in the Hunter Valley...Muswellbrook...no...Merriwa...I’m not too sure now where it was. A small Cop Station of only three staff. Opened only during daylight hours. The senior guy ended up as the Sergeant-in-charge at Kings Cross Station, one of the busiest Stations in the State. A beaut bloke...a fair dinkum cop. Whenever our paths crossed after this assignment I am about to relate, we would share a coffee or a beer depending on the time of day or night. I visited his home with and without Tellie frequently. He and his large extended family lived in Clovelly near the beach. A beautiful home...an example of a large Californian bungalow that held his family and his elderly in-laws. I went to his funeral not long ago... I knew his entire family...a great bloke...” I turned away to clear my throat, and so Angie could not see the tears welling in my eyes. “Yeah...as the senior member of the team I with my junior partner would be required

to visit Police Stations State-wide...both city and the bush...to refresh the Uniform Constables on procedures required on homicide cases...how to act; how to best protect the crime scene and not act like a herd of elephants stuffing up any forensic trace that may have been around...completely stuffing it up which happened more times than one wants to remember...the practise was dropped...oh...a fair while ago. Some said because of financial restraints imposed by the State Government of the time because they were adamant the same degree of teaching could be undertaken by a monthly e-mail or flyer...but as you and I know, these things are seldomly read by the rank and file...”

I again watched a young grummet riding down the face of a wave twice his size. Shaking my head at the nerve of these young riders. I, at that age would never tackle such huge swells...

“Yeah...” I continued. “We were at the Station when a call came through of shots having been fired on a farm known to the local cops. A firebrand farmer who once he had a skinful, would become violent with his entire family...the wife and five kids running for the hills on those occasions. Heading to the neighbour’s farmhouse a couple of kilometres away. We asked to accompany the local blokes out to the farm...once a local lass was hurriedly hired to work the phone while we were all out...hah! It is an eye-opener how some of these bush

Cop Stations work...usually on a shoe-string budget... but they continued with their daily chores never complaining about how the large city Stations receive the lion's share of the State budget with these small country Stations always missing out...just scraping by...being careful each financial year not to receive a 'Please Advise' on over-spending their annual budget... yeah...where was I?"

"The Station took a telephone call of shots fired on a farm that had a prior history of domestic violence..." Angie recounted.

"Yeah... we get out to the farm to see the farmer sitting in a rocking chair...no...one of those clapped out, worn-out vinyl-covered sofas on the veranda of the farmhouse...it was situated on a slight rise to prevent frequent floods...about once every dozen years or so, going through the house. He was sitting there rocking slightly on the old sofa...a shotgun on his lap. We spent an hour or two trying to get the chap to drop the shotgun...the Officer-in-Charge was fantastic, and I modelled my approach to similar situations on his tactics of that morning." I closed my eyes and rubbed them. Suddenly, I was feeling tired. I glanced at my watch.

"Time to head home...it is too late to head into the office. Drop me off at my joint and you drive the

Unmarked home. We will pick up the story to-morrow if we have not picked up a Case, huh?”

CHAPTER TWO

I did my early morning thing catching a ride with Tellie who always drove her small Hatchback to the Coroners and Medical Examination Laboratory out Lidcombe way. To be truthful she preferred to drive our large 4WD but with the added kilometres from our place to the Lidcombe Laboratories, it cost us more in fuel...not worth the trouble. She would drop me at Lidcombe Train Station which was a short train ride to Parramatta. A short walk from there to the Police Building...it was getting longer I was sure on each infrequent occasion we needed to adopt the exercise...

I was slowing down so my brain told me as I walked the few blocks to our tower building.

“Don’t get too settled Joe...” The Boss, Barry Clarke instructed. “A body has been discovered in one of those concrete-formed open stormwater drains out Croydon-way...probably some homeless guy who got caught in that storm last night.”

“The night shift guys handed it on, eh? From what I understand, they do not have enough work for

themselves so why have they passed it onto us?" I lamented.

"Arrh...they did not want to extend their shift into us dayshift Dees' time of responsibility..."

"How thoughtful of them..." I replied sarcastically, turning to lean against his door jamb as I looked across at the man who had been our Boss since the sudden death of Denny Turner from complications after a breast cancer operation. She had been perhaps our best Boss since our original DI JC Church aka Abbey. Barry Clarke was a fair boss but required several more years of leadership before he was anywhere near those two. "Any details, Boss?" I asked, not that interested,

"Arrh...no. A little early for that. When Angie makes it onto the floor, you can give yourselves the Case to examine...okay? It's a little hairy fairy without a Head Clerk dishing out the Cases in rotation to the staff. We need Soo back in the chair, but I fear she has gone for good...better money; better weather and a far better house to live in up in Queensland so she informed me in our last conversation...um...that will keep you from eating too many ice-creams during slack times..."

I wondered how in hell...and where he always obtained his field intelligence from as he was always dropping hints that he knew exactly where we were and what we were doing...

Even though Angie had rung the Boss and myself explaining there was a bad prang on the M5 that was holding up city-bound traffic I was still waiting impatiently for her to arrive at the office. I was no longer confident of leaving the office by myself to examine a crime scene...or to drive another Unmarked to the location which made me angry, but there was nothing I could do about it...and the Boss felt my discomfort.

“It is okay, Joe. I doubt they will have removed the body, waiting instead for you two to arrive. The body has washed down the drain for some distance with that sudden, sharp downpour we had early this morning, so I have been informed by the Uniforms at the site. I would hazard a guess and say that all trace of DNA evidence has been washed away from the body’s present location and where it may have been thrown into the drain further upstream...I doubt they will be able to identify that location either. You will have Buckley’s on this one I would suggest.” That is all I needed...another with negative thoughts! Especially my Boss!

Eventually Angie appeared striding purposely across the Squad floor looking frazzled, hassled, and irritated.

“There are some persons...” She retorted loudly. “Who should not be holding an NSW Driver’s License and should never have been given one!” Aiming her

discomfort at me as though I was the culprit for all bad drivers!

“Save it until we are in the Unmarked heading towards the crime scene. We have a body to view...”

As we passed the Boss’s Office, he beckoned us into his inner sanctum with a wave of his finger. Whatever he wanted us for did not look good judging by the expression on his face.

“Close the door and sit. This will not take long...” He looked sternly at me. “Joe? I doubt there is another person on the floor who has the same knowledge as you on everything contained in the Policy and Procedures Manual...so I don’t need to repeat anything, eh? This is not the first time this situation has occurred, and it is becoming too much of a bad practise amongst all the senior Dees on the floor...your vehicle is not your private chauffeur-driven limousine that you can authorise your junior officer to use for their own personal use...or yours. I will be preparing an e-mail to all staff reminding them of their need to follow the P&P Manual to the letter...I will not say any more on the subject...you have a homicide scene to examine...so get...and remember who can and cannot drive an official vehicle...”

CHAPTER THREE

We would have driven past the crime-scene site if it were not for the official vehicles parked higgledy-piggledy across the tiny bridge that spanned the open culvert. The backwater residential street was quiet and seldom trafficked which was the excuse of why they were parked in complete disorder according to the on-site Uniform Copper in charge of security, safety, and the on-site register.

We found Brenda Wzerlic sitting on the front bumper bar of her forensic van with two other of her team. She was enjoying a steaming mug of coffee and an apple... not the most enjoyable combination, I would have thought. The other two more traditional...a bottle of sugar-free coke and a meat pie each.

“Nice of you to join us Joe...” She mocked. I was about to give her an ear full. “Joe! Joe! We had one of our office staff and an assistant cutter caught up in the same shemozzle as Angie this morning ...Joe? You are losing your sense of humour the older you get...chill, old man!”

I held up a hand in apology, nodding several times. I blame my short fuse on having to sit around in the office for half the morning waiting for Angie to appear.

“I doubt you will learn any more than just looking at the body from the footbridge over there. It looks like a bundle of old clothes, and I doubt we will find much DNA trace on the body as it has been washed clean. We think...I repeat, we think that he was thrown into the drain from a point up near the park that borders the open drain and New Holland Parade one block over.” She stood, throwing the apple core into a bio-bin that would normally be a big no-no. In this Case, there would be next to nothing to save so the bio-bin would be under-utilised. “The Park is the local tail-light alley for local young people who still seem to think having sex in a vehicle is much preferred to a double bed... hah! I guess I could have been the same in my teenage years, but I am not about to divulge secrets of my youth. Um...you may have a problem running down those teenagers using the Park as their second bedroom...and then getting anything useful from them. I think they may have been otherwise occupied... having their hands full...” She laughed at her own joke. “Yes...good luck with that. The deluge early this morning caused minor flooding in the park, but we think our victim may have been bashed to an inch of his life in the park adjacent to the canal then thrown in... drowning in the process...” She held up her hand to stay any comment I might have made. “Not sure the Vic died from injuries received in the bashing...mostly around the head with bare fists and perhaps a baseball bat...or cricket bat...we will know for sure on the cause

of death once we have him on the cutting table...maybe tomorrow afternoon if there are no other homicide cases to examine..."

I nodded, pulled at my earlobe.

"Who discovered the body?" I asked.

"A middle-aged couple walking their three dogs just after sun-up. They live down the block..." She offered, pointing a finger down the street.

"Have you got a name for the Vic?" I requested.

"Yeah..." She picked up her iPad to read the contents on our Vic. "It needs to be confirmed by DNA comparison testing as he is on the Felons' Register, but we are sure it is Isla Pugowski known as 'Pug' Pugowski. Fingerprint analysis gave that much to us. Um...forty-nine years of age...a former inmate of Parkleigh Prison...completed a nine years' stretch around seven years ago. A stand-over strongman formerly of the illegal Tainted Angels Motorbike Club. His last stretch...his second...for possession, carrying an illegal firearm, three counts of assault with intent, one of attempted murder and resisting arrest...a nice all-round nasty guy! Records show he has remained clean since being released with no attempt at reconciliation with any of the illegal gangs...that was

supplied by the Police Intelligence Unit...we had to do something as we waited for you, Joe. Sorry..."

"Mmm..." I looked at my favourite Forensic Pathologist who had not that long ago returned to Australia after a lengthy hiatus overseas. "A trawl up and down the street asking residents if they had heard or seen anything." I suggested.

"Frankly Joe...I think that would be a waste of time as the body could have been washed down the stormwater drain from quite a distance away which would eliminate any involvement or witness from residents of this street..." Angie stated quietly. That made sense and I had opened my mouth with the suggestion before thinking...

Wzerlic nodded her agreement.

"Yeah, okay." I agreed. I had made an ill-informed decision that should not have been made. Both women glanced at one another. "Yeah...okay...we will organise the Uniform lads to perform the act along New Holland Parade opposite the park as the alternative?" Both women nodded. "Are there many residences facing the park on the other side of the road close to the entry and exit roads of the park?" I asked looking down the street. Wzerlic nodded her head. "Then we will extend the knock and question to that area only...Angie? Have a talk to the Sergeant-in-Charge of the Uniform lads.

Request him to order his lads to conduct that quest, eh?”

I suddenly thought that Angie had been just a bystander so far, as I questioned, ordered, and thought far afield on actions required...embarrassing myself with incorrect decisions in the process.

“How do we get around to the Park?” I asked Wzerlic as I turned to her.

“I will go with you...” Bre offered. “After I organise the removal of the body. We have hired a large front-end loader we think that will allow its arm to be lowered to the deck of the drain. We will place the body onto a litter, tie him in, and lift him up and over the handrail there onto the road surface...” She signalled for her crew to begin preparations as a large semi-trailer with an out-sized front-end loader on its trailer endeavoured to turn into the street. An expensive operation when I would have thought a little muscle power would have done the trick...the expense will be added to the running costs of the investigation which was always the responsibility of the leading Dee to keep in check. It was hardly ever questioned as each Case had certain similarities and differences that made guessing at a standard amount for each homicide case too difficult to assess.

Wzerlic came with Ang and I to direct us to the parkland. There was next to nothing to see in the park except still wet grass and ponds of water...

CHAPTER FOUR

I rang the Parole Board asking for the name of the Parole Officer responsible for Isla Pugowski's parole bond...agreeing to a time suitable to both of us to talk face to face...always my preferred option. After that, I organised a visit to Parkleigh Prison for inside information into our Vic. As we did not have a clue at this stage to the identity of the man's killer, Pug's life inside may offer up clues to that identity...hopefully...although I knew I was taking a long shot in persisting with this line of enquiry.

Nadene Hawkins had spent most of her adult life as a Parole Officer watching the same bods come and go in an endless cycle of reoffending criminals. This had not hardened her attitude as she always hoped that one in four reoccurring crims could be saved...and she was right according to the figures held by the Australian Crime Commission!

A stout woman with premature greying hair, she always had a welcoming smile and a chuckle for those with a similar sense of humour...which was plenty as her

sense of humour shaded towards gallows humour...not something that a successful Parole Officer should have.

“Pug Pugowski dead!? No! You must be mistaken... bullshit! I don’t believe you...” She exclaimed to our information. “How did he die? A bullet from a hidden assassin lying in wait, huh! That’s the only way someone would get the drop on him...Pug dead! Un-fucking-believable!” She had blanched at the news.

“It needs to be confirmed during the autopsy, but initial indications are that he was belted around the face until it would have been a bloody mash making identification difficult. We are relying on on-site fingerprint analysis for now, which will need to be confirmed along with DNA comparisons as his particulars are in the system having been in the Pen several times in his life....the Forensic Pathologist on-site believes he had his neck broken with either a baseball bat or the edge of a cricket bat...”

“Plenty of DNA evidence...” She replied still trying to come to terms with the man’s death.

“Sorry to disappoint you, Officer...hardly any...not a skerrick, I’m afraid...”

Angie explained the circumstances of Pug’s demise as Hawkins shook her head to every word.

“Dead!” She repeated, still a little unsure. “He was a good bloke under that thick skin of his. No-one dared cross him. He was top dog in the yard and as he ruled, there was few problems there...the screws left him be. He was lost for a while after being released and relied heavily on my advice...he was never going back inside so he would say to me repeatedly. He was out for what? No more than a couple of years. It was pay-back time for sure...some-one he belted while inside got to him... with a helper or three. There was no way some-one alone would have gotten the drop on him...even after all this time...no way!”

“Would you have any idea who that person or persons might be?” Angie asked quietly.

We were in an ‘open’ office situation where each Officer had her own ‘den’ surrounded by noise suppressant wall modules that were 160cms high on three sides. Even so, there was this constant drum of activity that the ‘noise suppressant’ walls could not soften. If an ex-crim was noisy or hostile in any way while being interview by his/her Parole Officer, that person was pounced on and immediately ejected and taken back to the cells until Court time granted him bail or prison time.

Hawkins shook her head. She was still having a problem accepting the inevitable...that her favourite

‘client’ was no more...she thought for some time about Angie’s question before shaking her head.

“There would be plenty of takers, that’s for sure. He put several into hospital...his favourite trick was to kick with all his weight behind him onto the opponent’s knee, cracking it backwards causing permanent damage and a limp for life for the man...about half a dozen went that way. I do not have a list just relying on what other clients of mine have told me. The Superintendent or Chief Warden at Parkleigh should be able to help you...if there is nothing else...I want to freshen up before my next ‘charge’ appears...a good morning to you. The world is a worse place with Pug gone...”

She stood and sniffled to show the depth of her feelings on the news. It would seem Pug was a favourite son of sorts to her...something that was rare as Parole Officers seldom allowed emotions to come between them and their clients...it was a short course in failure and early retirement according to some on the floor!

CHAPTER FIVE

Parkleigh Prison was one of two sold off in Australia when some clever politician thought it a grand idea to sell off public property for ready cash, not realising that the State Government still had to finance the running of

the establishments...it turned out to be a questionable decision as more complaints from prisoners of those two privately run prisons was more than double that of the State-run assets.

Several State-run investigations failed to lower or to cease the complaints...and no person was made accountable for these added complaints...the whole thing swept under the carpet.

Both prisons in Australia were purchased and run by a consortium of several American Companies based in Denver, Colorado which also owned and operated similar penitentiaries in various States around the U.S...profits were not in accordance with the accepted level of return for the buck outlaid according to whispers. Finances were always tight...

The Chief Warden was not available even though he was available when we had rung to make the appointment yesterday...very convenient. The Superintendent...or the CEO...or whatever, was not conversant with the day-to-day operations of the prison and could not shed light on any person hospitalised by being bashed in the 'yard' by the notorious Pug Pugowski!

Our visit a total waste of our time with Angie commenting as we drove away from the main prison

gates that it was as if we were seeking the combination to the lock on the front door of Fort Knox!

“Mmm...or we had been seeking the secret code into the launching of a thousand ICBM’s targeting Russia and China!” I added, making us chuckle. “Pug Pugowski sure has a reputation for people in responsible positions to cover up so it seems...” I observed. “Maybe the local hospital could supply us with the names of any crims who may have suffered serious knee injuries in the prison yard...” I suggested.

“Not without a Court Order, they won’t!” Angie responded angrily, frustration tempering her reply.

I settled back into the front passenger seat, closed my eyes, and wiped my hands over them. They were sore... and tired. I was tired wanting to slip into a sleep...but that was something I could never manage all my life... sleeping in a moving vehicle! I could never sleep but instead, suffered from a headache and slight nausea if I ever tried to nod off!

“So! What next, Einstein? We have been going down this road hoping some-one...something will pop out of the ether to indicate the possible killer of our infamous Pug Pugowski. Nothing so far!” She concluded, frustration showing through.

I shook my head tiredly.

“Too many bodies...it has been a lengthy career that has involved too many bodies over the years. I have seen every reason for someone killing another person and it does not vary by much when I think about it... money, lack of money, love, lack of love, envy, or revenge for some slight...nothing much else. One day I should count the number of dead bodies I have investigated over the years...”

“Yes...to write that book about them!” Angie shot back after she swore at a driver in front of us.

“Mmm...” was all I could manage as a response. She was still on about it!!

I suddenly sat up.

“The NDIS!” I shouted.

“What!?” Angie enquired, glancing across at me. Almost smashing into the vehicle in front of us that had stopped at the red traffic light.

“The National Disability Insurance Scheme...they would have details on every knee operation...or those unable to get around because of a serious and chronic knee injury...included in that list would be ex-criminals who were injured while in Parkleigh Prison, I would imagine...”

“Eistein? I knew you would come through...” Angie complimented me. A rare thing indeed!

CHAPTER SIX

It was the following morning before we could sit with the Boss and explain why we needed to obtain a Court Order to access NDIS records. He sat opposite us, occasionally nodding his head, closing his eyes. At the completion of my narration, he leant back in his large black leather executive chair folding his hands together over his ever-expanding stomach. He closed his eyes again and for one moment we both thought he was nodding off before he suddenly leant forward to place his elbows on his desktop, his head resting in his hands looking thoughtfully at both of us.

“Joe...Angie? The only thing is that the NDIS data bank search engine is involved and convoluted...for a search you type in say...Parkleigh Prison...inmates...injured persons...fractured knees...ten-year span, 2016—2025...hospitalisation...stuff like that. You will get a list of every inmate who has suffered a sprained ankle to a broken thumb to a covid and flu injection in that ten-year period which may account for every man and woman in that prison which will be a list a mile long. Understand? Which will give you one large headache

and a year of sorting through each name which may or may not give you a satisfactory conclusion...a total waste of your time in my book..." He nodded to emphasise his point.

We both had to reluctantly agree to his summation. I was angry at myself as I should have realised this home truth as I had experience with NDIS officials on other previous Cases.

"A better arrangement would be to involve the data base at Blacktown Hospital...that is the closest major hospital to the prison, isn't it?" He asked glancing from me to Angie and back again.

We both nodded. I opened my mouth to object or to suggest an alternative, having it shut by the Boss's stubby raised finger.

"Regardless of which hospital took these patients, they first would have had to be admitted to Blacktown to be examined and assessed with recommendations to which hospital...which major hospital like Westmead or RPA could carry out the reconstruction work on the damaged knee...there would be records pertaining to the inmate's name, age and so on as their first port of call. A Court Order to obtain that list of names is all you want, isn't it? Easy as..." He looked pleased with himself, leaning back in his large executive chair to adopt his favourite pose. That was to cross his arms and intertwine his

fingers over his generous waistline. A grin to effect a man of confidence.

I had to admit to myself that that direction of examination would be the most fruitful for us. I nodded accordingly. He just wasn't a pretty face...

"I will organise the Court Order application." The Boss offered. "Maybe a week before we get approvals..."

"Multiple fractures of the Patella, acute hyper-extension of the Tibiofemoral joint and severe dislocation and tearing of the surrounding ligaments..." Angie blurted, surprising both myself and the Boss. Both of us looking agog at the young woman. "Um...my first boyfriend while I was still in High School. He said he would become an international soccer player one day. His dream. He damaged his knee while doing a practise exercise one afternoon after school...his dreams were shattered and he still walks with a slight limp...sad really. I got to know the correct names for his injuries after visiting him in hospital so many times that I became...yeah...the relationship did not last as long as his hospitalisation...sad, huh?" She smiled.

I was still astounded at my young partner's knowledge of medical terms and the fact she remembered them over ten years later!

CHAPTER SEVEN

It was over a week before we got our hands on the list of nine suspects who *may* have assisted one another in killing Pug Pugowski. Our instincts told us it had to be more than one now that we knew more of the victim and his reputation.

We checked the names against the Felon Register which had the latest address details for each of the felons. This we checked against the Mobile Phone Register which was only available to the NSW Police Force and the AFP. We then double-checked those addresses against the Electoral Role to be satisfied with our findings.

The first name on our list was Albo ‘Allan’ Jelavic who had an address in Coalcliff which was north of Wollongong but south of Stanwell Park. Squeezed in by the Tasman Sea to the east and the precipitous cliff-line behind. A working coal mine still operated at the back of the small village and was one of the oldest operating coal mines in the Nation.

We turned off the old coastal highway to climb a steep gradient towards the coal mine pit head that we could see no more than three-hundred metres in front of us. Another turn to the left to parallel the coastline onto what at best, can only be described as a laneway. On the high side of this one lane patchy, bumpy bitumen ride

were a series of cottages of similar design...older-type, small weatherboard cottages built by the mine company for its workers. Basic dwellings...

An old bloke was sitting in a rocking chair staring out to sea. The narrow, low veranda line at the front of the middle cottage gave him all the shade he required. Wisps of long strands of white hair danced about his scalp from the constant sea breeze. A permanent squint against the early morning eastern sun reflecting off the sea below. As we alighted, he nodded slowly, his head resting on his hands that were clinging to the handle of an old briar walking cane.

“Coppers...” He wheezed. “Knowed the minute I sees yer fancy ride crawling along me street that yers are looking for me. Got me beat why yers are looking for me...I ain’t done nuttin’ worthy of yer visit to me humble home. Social Housing with the Gov’mnt taking control of these coupla cottages...I ain’t complaining as it is warm, comfortable and all I need for a little rent that is controlled as part of yer pension.”

I nodded as I stepped up onto the veranda. Angie had remained in the Unmarked.

“Your knee injury...” I commented with a nod towards his leg that was held in place by an external brace.

“Yeah...well...yer only let it happen the once...that was bad enough! Every time I move that leg, me knee tells me to stop because of the pain, and I think of the bastard who done it to me...”

“Isla Pugowski...” I mentioned quietly.

“Yeah...Pug...yer never go back for seconds as he would take out the other knee leaving yer in a bloody wheelchair for the rest of yer life...” He nodded to make the point strongly.

“He was killed the other week...” I flatly informed the man.

“Hah! Let me know who done it and I’ll shake his hand...no...it would take more’n one bloke to blind-side the bastard. Two or three...they deserve all they get in congratulations for getting to the bastard...”

“Their only future time in prison for homicide murder...” I replied. “That will be their reward when we nab them...”

“I guess them’s the breaks, eh? For doing the right thing...they deserve a bloody medal. Have ta be more’n two to get past his guard...three or four...”

“All having had their knees busted by Pug, eh?”

“S’pose...payback.” He replied, nodding slowly. “The bloke who once said crime don’t pay musta been a crim himself. Every time I thought I was on the edge of the big time, I was nabbed. Bin poor all me life but at least I got the Pension coming in regular-like now that keeps me head above water...some might say I shouldn’t get no money from the Gov’ment...but those that complain don’t make the rules...”

“Just as well...eh?” I rejoined to hear him wheeze and cough up a decent wad of phlegm that he spat my way. Thankfully with no force with most of it dribbling down his chin. He wiped this off with a filthy-looking handkerchief that he scrounged from a top pocket in his shirt.

I wished him well and left.

CHAPTER EIGHT

We headed along the Appin Road towards Appin as that is where the second on our list lived. Living with his daughter and son-in-law who both claimed the Carer’s Pension for taking care of their disabled father.

Albert ‘Bert’ Reynolds was his name.

Again, a story of constant pain that left the man sour though his spirits picked up after learning of Pugowski's demise. He stood at the ajar front door with callipers to both legs and crutches to help him stand. Leaning with his shoulder against the door jamb as though he would fall if he did not have that support as well. He did not ask for details but was pleased with our news of Pugowski's passing, closing the front door of the premises in our faces saying the man deserved his fate.

For the rest of the week, we interviewed all those listed...nine men who experienced constant pain caused by Pug Pugowski during their stay in Parkleigh Prison. All pleased to hear of their opponent having been killed.

'Could not have happened to a more deserving bloke,' was the common cry. There was not a single person who itched my nose...none of the men interviewed could get to a suburb of Sydney let alone kill the guy. *'You could never get the drop on the bastard, let alone close enough to bash his head in...'* was another common remark!

I sat in our Unmarked scratching my head. We had hit that dead-end again which was not uncommon on any of our homicide cases. My Mobile began its buzz before breaking out in the musical prelude of a Hot

August Night by Neil Diamond. I placed the mobile into the dock so that any conversation was broadcast through the vehicle's radio speakers...Angie does not like being left in the dark.

“Joe? Bree Wzerlic. We have just finished the autopsy on Isla Pugowski...”

“I thought that procedure wasn't due until early next week...” I replied, surprised at the news. I would have attended even though I am not a fan of witnessing autopsies!

“We had a couple of simple operations which allowed us to bring Pugowski forward to this afternoon...I have yet to write up the Report, so this is an informal explanation of the man's death. The final report could be in about ten days' time. The man did not drown. The damage to his face and skull were not impact injuries and I would bet my experience on those injuries being abrasion-type injuries sustained as his body was washed, dragged down the concrete base of the drain. I would also predict that his neck was broken as he fell... and that he was already dead when that occurred. He was not thrown into the stormwater drain...more than likely rolled into it, falling awkwardly hitting his head and fracturing his neck when he hit bottom...the drop from the bottom of the drain to the shoulder...or to the level of the surrounding parkland varies but is around

two and half metres...a fall of that distance could/would result in a broken neck if the fall is awkward...”

“There is a lot of guesses in that summation, Bree...” I concluded.

“Yes...but I would be confident in my synopses being close to if not spot on to what occurred...and he was shot three times in the chest at close range...” Angie turned to me, a frown indicating her concern on a minor matter, I was sure. “There is no Gun Shot Residue or powder burns but I would contend that as he was washed down the drain for some two hundred yards to where he was discovered, it would have been as good as a washing machine effect on his clothing cleansing all DNA and forensic trace...the closeness of the bullet hole cluster to his chest would indicate a shooter who was well-practised in that type of kill...I would hazard a guess to say a similar manner of killing a victim could be in your Register...”

“Mmm...our assailant knew of the weather forecast, perhaps...” I commented. The content of Wzerlic’s last summation completely lost on me. I was thinking of something else not paying attention to her last words.

“Maybe yeah...maybe no. That would be a summation hard to prove, old man.” Bree rejoined though there was no spite in her words. The exact opposite in fact

with a chuckle to add to her words as she raised her eyebrows towards Angie.

Both women were noticing the little ‘things’ creeping into the Senior Detective’s actions, thoughts and reactions.

“Mmm...it still seems like a revenge killing but our assailant was not an inmate at Parkleigh. He obtained his blown knee injuries in another prison...what other prison was Pugowski interned in?” I asked no-one. There was silence for some moments.

“Perhaps your culprit never was on the end of Pugowski’s flying foot...he never had a smashed-up knee, but he carried out the shooting of the guy for some other reason...a slight that occurred while the two shared the Yard at another prison, perhaps...” Angie offered.

I shook my head, immediately thinking that the culprit must have held a grudge for several years which did not compute with me. That did not make sense to me...but it did to Bree Wzerlic who applauded Angie on her ‘out of left field’ thinking.

Such vengeance cases where the slight goes on for centuries was a well-worn fact especially in some Mediterranean regions, I thought after some reflection,

completely lost in that divergent thought and not on the present-day facts of the Case.

CHAPTER NINE

We were not delaying the inevitable of viewing the video footage of traffic flowing along New Holland Parade and the entrance into New Holland Park. It was just that we had other priorities where we were out of the office for over a week...that is my reason in any case!

“We have nothing on our Vic’s vehicle?” Angie asked.

“Nothing...though we did not expect much if anything, but the vehicle had to be forensically examined just in case our Suspect touched any of the panels of the Toyota Prado...the new model too which meant our Vic was not short of a quid...a bit surprising for an ex-con, don’t you think?” I commented looking at the back of my young partner. She shrugged as she typed the report of our recent absence from the office for the Murder Book. Totally engrossed in her exercise. To me, the ownership of a new model vehicle could only mean one thing...the selling of drugs...to me not a jump too far, though there was no record of illegal activity by the man!

I was beginning to realise that these indirect lines of thought were taking me away from the Case and its relevant evidence. My mind drifting and not concentrating on all the facts we were gathering on the Case.

We had decided to use the large flat TV screen in the Electronics Room. This allowed the two Interview Rooms to be utilised by the one Control Room which was in the middle of the two Rooms...and there was much preferred equipment which allowed us to manipulate the reverse, speed up, multi-screen and zoom capabilities of the video feeds. Something I could not do while viewing the same video feeds at my desk...

I settled back in one of the comfortable chairs while Angie staffed the controls sitting alongside the Electronics Officer. I would have been lost if I had tried...

“That is the Vic’s vehicle entering the park...the Toyota Prado.” I pointed a finger towards the large screen. “No other vehicles followed him in until some...” She looked up at the timer in the corner of the screen. My flimsy searches using my desktop computer screen did not have so many gadgets attached...how I could have used these facilities the last time that I spent hours viewing video feeds...on my last Case while Angie was

off on medical grounds. “Um...ten minutes later when that Toyota ‘Troopie’...looks a bit battered about and it is an early model. The guy must enjoy bush bashing...” She commented quietly, almost to herself. We watched in silence as two sedans entered the park. More than likely young kids wanting to use the tail-light area further into the park from where we assumed our action occurred. Twelve and half minutes later there were three muzzle flashes in very quick succession...a practised action I thought.

It was another eleven minutes before the ‘Troopie’ exited the park and sped off down New Holland Parade in the same direction it had come from earlier.

“Can we get the number plate of the vehicle as it entered...or left the park?” I asked Angie.

“We’ll try...” She replied as she fast reversed the video feed to when the 4WD entered the Park entrance slowly. “Hmm...” She muttered as she manipulated the zoom and brightener around the rear of the vehicle. “A partial...” She offered. “I don’t think that will be enough for identification purposes.” She added slowly.

I wrote down the partial number plate details and as Angie fast forwarded until the vehicle was exiting the park entrance, I tapped into the Motor Registry data base hoping to obtain a match.

“Sorry Joe...the number plate for the front of the vehicle is missing...any good?” She asked as she looked across at me. Me still focused on the task at hand. I paused to shift around in my chair to look at my young partner.

“What model year do you reckon?” I asked my partner as I nodded. There was insufficient information and I was hoping the year model may help in the search.

“Bloody Hell! I would not have a clue...and by the looks it has so many ‘extras’ added I doubt anyone would reliably ping the year model ...” She asserted.

“Mmm...yeah. Fatter wheels and tyres. Bullbar and electric winch. The latest LED driving lights. Two-way radio antennae...a short range and long range UHF receiver...I’ll lay odds he has a V8 plopped into the engine bay and special seats...with a fold-out shade cloth and a cabin-top sleep-out tent...a very distinctive vehicle which...hmm...we should send off a couple of photograph copies to the various 4WD Accessory places...they may be able to identify the vehicle...” I rubbed my tired and sore eyes wondering if I should have an eye check-up...it had been a while.

I was ready to call it quits for the day...and I would leave once we had completed this task.

“...and the driver!” Angie added forcefully. “Though images of him will be extremely grainy if we can produce them at all.”

We created a photo montage of various views of the vehicle that Angie cleverly enhanced, placing an introductory letter on top with the official NSW Police Force insignia at the top with our police badges names and mobile phone numbers and signatures at the bottom requesting any information as to the vehicle and its owner...creating an e-mail list of likely establishments of 4WD Accessories, Parts and Workshops hoping for a quick response.

I had not realised the number of 4WD Parts, Accessories and workshops there were in the State with everyone given an e-mail ‘flyer’ that had been designed and sent by Angie on the Friday afternoon after my early exit.

Yep, I left early feeling hung over with something I had picked up according to my own diagnosis leaving Angie to finish off our quest...

CHAPTER TEN

I felt terrible waking up on the Saturday morning, every joint stiff and sore to move...it took me the entire weekend to fight off the wog or whatever I had and when I woke on the Monday morning, I still felt hung over...I did not return to work until the Wednesday...I will blame my age for the slow recuperation period...and maybe a tinge of no enthusiasm to return to work... maybe!

“How are you feeling?” Angie asked, her concern showing after I hobbled into work.

“Hah! A lot better than late on Friday night. I reckon I went through a packet of anti-inflammatories and a packet of analgesics over the weekend...an overdose situation for sure. Every joint in my body was stiff and sore...”

“Yeah...it is going around...” Sounding as though she was an expert in that field.

“Thanks for that, Doctor...we do any good with those flyers we sent out late Friday?”

“Yeah...that *I* sent out, you mean without any help from you. Two replies in the Newcastle area. A visit up there, eh? Yeah...and another from a firm in Bathurst. We should investigate the two Newcastle firms first... what do you reckon?”

“Sounds good to me...” I countered. “To-morrow?”

“How about now. You are late for work...at least an hour past your normal start time but we can get up there and back by normal knock-off time...what do you think?”

“You’re driving, Jack Brabham...I will just sit there holding onto the panic handle with my eyes closed.”

“I ain’t that bad, am I?”

“Miss Lead Foot, you are known as far and wide...”

CHAPTER ELEVEN

I again began reminiscing as we drove north up the M1 Motorway at a leisurely one hundred which was slower than the one-ten speed limit.

“I don’t know if it was only a dream, a nightmare or I had a high temperature and was delirious...Tellie said the following morning that I was groaning loudly and flaying about...so badly she went into the girls’ bedroom to have a decent night’s sleep...for the entire three nights that I was showing signs of the wog. All I could see were these faces...mask-like...no bodies, just these masks of people who had been victims of violent

deaths. I recognised some...but they were all floating on this viscous substance...just their faces as though I was turning a page which displayed a new face every time...I think this occurred maybe two times over the weekend...weird, eh? I reckon they were victims of violent crimes that I had investigated throughout my career...”

Angie glanced at me. “Yeah...weird alright. You okay about it...no flashbacks or sudden tremors-like?”

“No...no! I’m fine about it but it made me think about my retirement...end of November this year to coincide with my sixty-seventh birthday...rounds it out nicely.”

“You’re sure...” Angie again glanced at me.

“Yep...I’m sure.”

“How long before Tellie can retire on full superannuation hand-out?”

“Yeah...well...there’s the sticking point. She has another seven years before she can retire at sixty-seven on the full package. Hah! I’ll be eighty-four by then...if I am still alive!”

“Don’t talk like that!” Angie admonished. “It sounds as though you want to tempt fate.” She frowned as she glanced over at me. “Mmm...seven years...what are you going to do waiting for her?”

“Do a bit of travelling with the caravan on the back... and yeah, maybe begin to write that great Australian novel...”

“You think!?”

“Yep...I have been thinking seriously about your suggestion to turn some of my experiences into a book...you know?”

“Seriously!?”

“Yep. Why not...all I must do is concentrate hard enough and the words should come easily... hopefully...”

“You can give it a try in any case...here’s the Newcastle by-pass off-ramp...it isn’t that far to the first address...” There was silence for some minutes as she negotiated the high-level off-ramp to head towards the outer suburbs of Newcastle before she spoke up, a frog in her throat. “I’ll miss you Joe...heaps.” She nodded as she glanced across at me. She angrily wiped tears that were welling in her eyes. She felt uncomfortable displaying such emotions so openly in front of me when I was the subject of her tears...

“You’ll marry in with a new partner who you can train...and you’ll get promoted to a Grade Three Dee...”

“You think!?”

“Yep, I know! You will have to be to permit your new junior partner to become your driver...”

“Don’t let the Boss hear you say that and besides...I enjoy driving too much to hand over responsibility to someone else...”

CHAPTER TWELVE

We showed the bloke behind the counter our ID Cards.

“Yeah...nah...I should have been a little more specific when I spoke to the young lass the other day...”

“That was me, sir.” Angie interrupted, holding up her hand.

“Oh! You sounded so young over the phone...yeah...I remember working on that Troopie...he had purchased a cheap Chinese piece of shit winch which he had installed himself, so he said. It burnt out the minute a load was applied...we installed a superior quality winch and connected the electrics up properly...he paid cash...over a thousand bucks...gee...that was...about seven years ago. My Accountant may have the original paperwork and receipt...maybe not...it was a cash job.”

He raised his eyebrows. “The bloke was a sour old bloke who did not like being told he did a cow of a job fitting the original winch...um...that is about all I can tell you. Have forgotten the Number Plates on the Troopie and the bloke’s name...he lived not that far away...around Jesmond I think...sorry to make you come all this way for nothing...”

“You can’t think of his name?” Angie pressed, a little miffed.

“Gee...um...no...could have been Norman Greene...not too sure. No...Sorry, but I really don’t recall.” A little embarrassed.

I shook my head thinking it was okay taking the bloke’s cash for the job suspecting it has been illegally obtained but you cannot remember the chap’s name...what a dishrag, I thought as I exited the building a little irate!

“It was a while ago Joe.” Angie stated quietly as she unlocked the Unmarked...making excuses for the man feeling my anger.

I scrolled up the name as we sat in our Unmarked out the front of the 4WD Accessory and Installation Warehouse for little result. Sure, there were several Norman Greenes listed in the Motor Registry data base but none of them drove a Toyota Troopie with only one listed as living in a suburb of Newcastle.

“Shit!” I swore. “This has been a total waste of time...”

“Settle down Joe. We have one more Accessory place to visit which is only a couple of suburbs over from here...let’s not blow a poople valve just yet, eh? You will give yourself a bloody heart attack ten months before you are due to retire...that would not be a good outcome for an old bloke like you...”

She had to continually remind me of my age...and I bet I will hear continuously how close my retirement date is and how I need to take care of myself...phhhh!

We parked at the front of a factory-type building like the one we had just visited. Walked into the Reception Area where a young ‘bimbo’ sat managing the phones...times were busy. She nodded towards an open office door as though that was the level of her responsibilities. I knocked as a middle-aged man who looked after himself, stood. Greeted us with a smile and an invitation to sit opposite him at his desk. It was the tidiest desk I had ever seen, beating mine by several loose A4 pages...we showed the man our credentials... he nodded.

“Bin expecting youse sometime this week. That Toyota Troopie...the one in your message text...we had it here for a week. It appears the chap was planning a trip away...for some time, I’d say...”

I moaned. That is all we needed...having the bird fly away...

“How long ago was this?” Angie asked. I figured he would be more receptive to an attractive young woman going on his Receptionist outside his Office, so she asked the questions as I looked around the Office.

It seems our man was busy planning the homicide of Pugowski for several months before doing a disappearing act afterwards going on the dates.

“Um...” He tapped away on a keyboard positioned on a side table to his desk. “Yes...December three years ago...early in the month...he wouldn’t take no as an answer to our deflection advising the man we were fully booked up before the Christmas break...always are at that time of the year...everyone leaves it to the last minute to have their vehicle checked over or bits and pieces added for that long-planned bush camping... or down by the river or the dam lake holiday...yeah... always the last bloody thing needed doing expecting us to do miracles with the client not understanding why we couldn’t satisfy their needs. Arrh...he repeated several times he was willing to pay cash for everything he wanted done...”

“Which was?” Angie pressed.

“Doesn’t matter how the customer pays...if he pays for the work done without any hassles...um...” He lent towards his computer screen. “Um...yeah... fridge/freezer on a roll-out slide that then dropped down to waist height connected to a new 12V system which we installed. The original electrics he must have done himself. I was surprised he didn’t have a short and a fire going on the ‘handyman’ effort ...um...double deep-cycle batteries and the best electronic 12V charging system on the market...um...a roof-top tent... he already had a roll-out awning on the passenger side of the Troopie...and two swing-out solar panels attached to either side of the truck covering the rear side windows...his design actually, which was a clever arrangement as either one could be adjusted to suit the passage of the sun. This connected into the electrics... better suspension system with added lifters...couple of other things that put the bill out over seven grand...he still paid in cash...”

“What was his name?” Angie continued.

“Arrh...yes.” He again glanced at his computer screen as he tapped and scrolled until he had the information he required. “Yes...that’s right! He gave a false name... he showed us a false Driver’s License...Norman Greene...I picked the bogus License in one, but it didn’t matter as he paid the bill in full...in cash. I mean, no-one pays in cash these days...or by cheque! It’s all

done by plastic nowadays! Sometimes through a Bank Transfer when the bill is high...over a couple of thousand...but he paid the lot in cash! Drug money, I reckon. He looked and acted like a crim...but his money was good. I still gave him a receipt with the year model of the Troopie, his bogus name and the vehicle Number Plates. I was very suspicious and noted his residential address...I drove over there later that day... it was a Woolworths Supermarket in the Jesmond Shopping Centre...clever, yeah! He was a surly bloke. Not into small talk or nothing...didn't want to communicate at all unless it was about what he wanted done on the truck...a weird bloke...but his money was good..."

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

I glanced at the copies of the Work Order for the vehicle and the receipt for payment made in full as the Boss of the Firm handed copies to Angie who passed them on to me without looking at them. As though she was silently displaying the pecking order between the two of us. He was planning on disappearing going on what additional works he wanted on his vehicle...into the bush where he may feel more comfortable...but no-one can disappear for ever was my thought.

The Boss proudly showed us through the Accessory Showroom and the heart of the business...the mechanical workshop bays where close to a dozen 4WDs were being worked on for various 'add-ons' and extras...big business.

We wished the man well for his cooperation. I slid into the passenger seat and turned the laptop towards me. Typed up the Motor Register Department and provided the number plates that were noted on both the Work order and the Receipt...

"Mmm...this guy is crafty...false number plates belonging to a Mazda hatchback, address here in Newcastle. A Sandra Cecelia Worthington. Angie, let's take a spin around to that address, eh? We have bugger-all else to do...except to head back to Sydney...and it is way too early for that to happen..."

"Compute the address into the GPS so we can get there by the most direct route. I do not want to spend half the day going around in circles in half-a-dozen Newcastle suburbs. The road system around here is a bloody nightmare...worse than Canberra...I've got lost every time I have been up here without the aid of a GPS thing-a-ma-jig...yes, Canberra too!"

I went to do as directed and paused. I had forgotten how to do the simple computation. Angie glanced over at me before turning the engine over and starting up the air-

conditioning. It was the middle of winter, but the interior of the vehicle was stuffy...we had been longer in the Warehouse and Office than anticipated, the walk through the shop accessory area had been interesting but what amazed me was the main mechanical workshop area. The floor was sparkling clean; every vehicle worked on had to first have a thorough steam clean and the number of 4WDs up on work-lifts staggered me...this was big business!

I carefully obeyed Angie's step by step instructions to compute the address of Sandra Cecilia Worthington into the GPS. Worthington may have owned the Mazda Hatchback at some stage but it still was a two-way bet going on the craftiness of our Suspect.

I doubted I would recall those same instructions tomorrow morning...I'll blame that on a slowly retiring mind...or at least a less than an enthusiastic bone for the GPS thing. In my heyday, you used a hard-copy Street Directory which seemed to work alright as long as your partner...or yourself could read the bloody thing...and I guess this GPS thing-a-ma-jig got you to your destination quicker and in a more direct route...and could inform you of traffic flow, traffic hold-ups or accidents...something that a Street Directory could never do...but it still served its purpose...am I old-fashion or what? Am I regressing? I guess I am to some degree...

To double-check the ownership of the residential address I telephoned through to the Registrar-General's Department. As a security thing, they noted my name, grade, badge number, and my place of employment. They would ring our central telephone reception area who would plug them through to my mobile...seemed like a heavy-handed method to me but everyone was becoming skittish after too many telephone scams had been reported...or been successful...sincere callers as well would be subject to the same rigmarole. A pain in the butt but a symptom of today's society...

It was confirmed that a Sandra Cecelia Worthington owned the house outright at the address we were heading towards...another box ticked.

I had floated the idea of a retirement date for my birthday in late November of this year to see what the reactions would be...to say I was disappointed with both Tellie's and Angie's responses would be an understatement! I did not think I was quite ready for that date yet though everyone else including my extended family and former partners thought it a grand idea!

Says a lot, eh?

I opened the 'Felons' Register' to tap in the woman's name...surprise, surprise...she came up on drug

charges doing a thirty-month stint in the local women's work experience prison...an earlier stint on similar charges and a sealed juvenile record. She had led a life of crime up to her last stint in that Work Experience Prison out Lithgow way...an easy sentence only given to those who the Court decides was possible of rehabilitation. It appeared the Court was correct as the woman had a clean slate for the past fourteen years though I would guess the dwelling had been purchased with drug money somewhere along the line previous to her last conviction...back in those days the State Laws weren't so hard on all property and goods and chattels deemed purchased by money from illegal means surrendered to the State...I was pleased when those Laws were legislated and enacted...

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

I exhaled loudly...

"You sound disappointed..." Angie responded with a chuckle.

"Well...you know..." Jutting my chin towards the house on the opposite side of the street.

"What did you want? Something like the Bates Motel out of Psycho?"

We both laughed after which I shook my head.

“That shower scene in Psycho...it’s a classic! Because of the strict censorship rules back then, they could not show the actual stabbing...you just saw the shadowy hand holding a knife continuously falling in a stabbing motion behind a semi-translucent shower curtain...and the blood flowing down the bathtub drain...the power of suggestion, eh? I can still conger up that scene even though it was in black and white with the film financed on a shoe-string budget and the film crew all coming from the TV set of the ‘Alfred Hitchcock Show.’ I was young back then...but geez...it scared the bejeesus out of me...”

“Do you want to go and knock on the door. See if the woman is home...” Angie asked breaking the spell of my imagination.

“May as well...we are here so why not. You take the back door, okay?”

We both walked briskly across the street, me heading towards the front porch area and the front door while Angie headed towards the back of the house. I waited before knocking loudly on the brightly painted door. There was a faint sound of footfalls and the door opened suddenly.

“The back door was open with the insect screen door unlocked...um...yer better take a look inside, Joe.” Angie proposed as she kept the door open with her foot for my entry. I followed her down the short hallway, the smell of death lingering in the stuffy closed-up house. I poked my head into what was the main front bedroom. The woman’s body lay on a large queen-sized bed, a small fluffy dog lying beside her. Both looked as though they were asleep. Pillows had fallen onto the floor beside the bed suggesting both had been smothered which was my summation.

“Arrh...we better call it in...” I suggested as we both headed towards the front door, closely it quietly for no known reason as you cannot wake the dead!

As per protocol, we had informed the local Hunter Command of our presence in their area of responsibility for the day. I rang the same number to inform them what we had found... Alby ‘Al’ Hans Freedman aka Norman Greene was taking care of all loose strings so it would appear though that was a jump in logic based on nothing but an itchy nose!

We sat in the Unmarked patiently waiting for the official response to occur.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

We slid the windows down expecting a short stay before help arrived.

Just to begin a conversation instead of dozing off waiting for the local cavalry, I began...a smirk to show I was not being serious...well...not too serious.

“You ever watched that situation occur where President Trump was almost killed by a bullet to the head? Instead, it clipped his ear...” I began suddenly causing Angie to jerk in surprise. I think she may have begun to fall asleep. She fluttered her eyelids, briefly shaking her head.

“What are you talking about, Joe?” She asked sleepily.

“You know...you ever wonder if it was all fair dinkum?”

“Not really, no, though it is a pity the guy missed as far as I am concerned...”

“Mmm...you didn’t hear the report of the Assassin’s long gun...or the report of the FBI’s long gun in response that killed the sniper...”

“What!? You suggesting it was all staged!?” Angie suggested sarcastically. “You off on one of your theories again, Joe...bloody hell!! God give me strength!”

“No...truly...listen. With all the cameras and sound recordings about on that day, not one picked up the two reports of the long guns...and the shot that supposedly killed the sniper was an impossible shot from where that marksman was...he could not have shot the sniper in the chest as the guy was lying on his stomach...and if you nick your ear, it doesn't bleed profusely...as it supposedly did with blood running down between the President's fingers...as though the aorta had been severed!”

“Yeah...it did, Joe!” Angie wanted to ensure the truth remained intact and not twisted by my paranoid illusions...

“No...watch the footage again. The President grabs at his ear before the Secret Service guys pull him down behind the rostrum. When he stands back up there is blood running down his hand as he holds his ear suggesting the bullet nicked his ear...a close thing. He was in hospital for one day only...not even a day...an afternoon in fact. To plug the hole or gap left by the trajectory of the bullet they would have used skin taken from his buttock more than likely...that section would not take in his ear and would always look like a white patch...have you ever seen that remnant white bit on the President's ear? No?? The operation would have kept him in hospital for longer than a couple of hours...

and there has been little of the sniper and his history. There was never any forensic operation of the roof before the sniper was removed...and you never saw the sniper removed as a dead body would be removed from the roof. He would not have been dropped to the ground...and the president and his bodyguards stood very quickly after the bullet supposedly grazed his ear...they just stood back up again as though they knew there was no further danger...get what I mean?"

"What are you suggesting Joe. That this was all a staged job? Why?"

"Um...his popularity was lagging at the time but after the attempt on his life, his popularity jumped...after the incident...the Yanks! They are a separate breed of animal..." I grinned, proud of my summation. I too was disappointed the bullet had not landed closer into his head...

"Joe! Joe! You and your theories...you are as bad as the Yanks with all those conspiracy theories..."

"There has never been a spat of conspiracy theories on the attempt on Trump's life coming out of the U.S. Why not as that goes against the grain of all other conspiracy theories that the Yanks spit out on just about everything else. The Yanks are renown for such things...just look at the shooting death of JFK...they have had so many TV shows on the assassination of the man...even a full-

length film for God's sake. Mmm...yeah...I will leave it up to you...hear comes the cavalry..."

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

I was surprised that Newcastle, as the second largest city in the State of New South Wales did not have a dedicated Forensic Pathologist. Instead, the role was rotated amongst the Postmortem Specialists from several public hospitals. This Officer 'on call' was older than me and instead of being a doddering old fool, was one quick-witted and quick of step man having administered his opinion within ten minutes before walking quickly from the house...his responsibilities over until he met the victims again at the cutting table.

His verdict? Both the woman and the dog were suffocated more than likely by having a pillow placed over their heads. As there were no defensive wounds or any signs of a struggle during the death process, he surmised both had been anaesthetised...and suggested there could have been sufficient sleeping tablets in both their systems to have caused an overdose. *'The Assailant was a cautious man, nervous of using a gun as the sound may have alerted the close neighbours. He planned these deaths carefully...but why kill the dog?'*

was the final words of the Specialist as he left the house.

“Why indeed?” I murmured in reply to his receding figure.

We undertook the protocol shown to me by DI Church aka Abbey when he had been my first Boss in the Murder Squad. Back forty-five years ago. I have stuck with the process at every death scene in a domestic setting. Angie had enthusiastically taken up the practise as well.

We opened every drawer and door and peered into the internal wardrobe spaces inside the home. We then reversed the procedure to do it all over again but in the opposite direction. It was Angie who discovered the handgun under the pillow of presumably Norman Greene’s bed position. I sent that off asap to our Ballistics people in Sydney to compare bullets taken from the body of Pugowski with those test-fired from the handgun. Hopefully, we will have a match...

I wondered why the man would leave such an important and revealing piece of evidence behind as he fled the house. Perhaps that was it...he had fled from the house overcome with emotion at carrying out the deed of killing his missus. No...that did not compute as every other murder he had committed was without an ounce of emotion...all very cold blooded...he could not care

less standing toe to toe as he had shot his victims previously in a comparable manner.

You try to get into the minds of your assailants...to figure them out; to understand what drives them. This guy was unreadable!

We then went to interview the neighbours on both sides of the death house and the three houses behind the dwelling...to be surprised.

In this job you rarely have surprises that would bowl you over but, in this case, we were mightily surprised at what those neighbours had stated. Missus Worthington ruled the home with an iron rod even forcing Norman Greene to sleep out in his Troopie for a slight that he had committed. He was putty in the eyes of the woman. This man, who could stand eye to eye with his victims before shooting them multiple times in the chest without batting an eyelid being controlled by this tiny woman was hard to comprehend!

Don't that beat all!

Human Nature with all its nuances and differences never failed to surprise me and this example was one of the most inexplicable of my entire long career...

“Amazing, huh?” Angie proffered as we strode back towards the death house still alive with forensic officers

and the flash of a forensic photographer's camera.

"Mmm...yeah!" I chuckled in reply. I pulled at my earlobe as we stepped up onto the front path that led to the front steps of the dwelling. I stopped when we stood on the narrow veranda. "Where would the man go who wanted to disappear with a Troopie that had all the bells and whistles attached? Into the bush, I reckon. He would need to emerge from his hidey-hole every now and then just to stock up on supplies...and he had his dog with him...a Staffordshire Terrier...a good watch dog, I bet...but National Parks and State Forests do not allow camping with a dog in tow in those areas...so where would he go?"

"To some-one's place that he knew of...like a fellow crim whom he befriended while in the clink..." Angie muttered. "Can we fish that out...I mean, we do not even know what Pen he was in, do we?"

"Hmm...nah...I'll look up the Felons Register while you get onto his parole officer who might have an idea along those lines...perhaps someone who now lives in a secluded spot...near a National Park or a State Forest. Often crims like many Vietnam Veterans find it difficult to assimilate back into society and prefer the solitude and aloneness of the bush...or a small village perhaps."

Angie stopped walking to scroll up the necessary number that we had attached to the inside of the front

cover of the latest Murder Volume. I heard her swear under her breath before she was transferred to the number she wanted. She sat in the rocking chair on the front veranda of the dwelling as the two bodies were carefully passed through the ajar front door and insect screen door. I headed in the opposite direction across the street to sit in the passenger front seat of our Unmarked, turning the laptop around so I could work on it...I paused not recalling what I wanted to do. I was about to yell out to Angie when it came to me.

I scrolled up the details and the latest photographs of the fawn Troopie that the Accessory Firm had taken after fitting the roof-top tent and other add-ons to the vehicle. Typed in 'unknown' for the number plates and then requested an 'All Points' to be issued for this vehicle and its driver. The vehicle was not to be approached as the person is considered armed and dangerous. I sent this off to the Boss who would flesh out the request and send a 'flyer' off to the relevant Police stations in the State, local NPWS Rangers and Forestry Officers, the Rural Fire Brigade teams, and several SES volunteer teams all stationed around the Newcastle area. We would enlarge the search area if no results came in from around the Hunter region.

I watched as the body of Missus Worthington and her dog were stretchered to a morgue van to be transported to a hospital postmortem autopsy room. We would have

confirmation of her death within a week the local Sergeant-in-Charge assured us.

Angie came to join me sitting quietly as the bodies were wheeled into the waiting van.

“I’ve been wondering...” I began.

“No, you haven’t...don’t wonder...” Angie interrupted as she turned the motor over. “I think our presence is no longer required and we can head towards home, huh? The Parole Officer came up with a name...Harry Sydcombe who was in the clink at the same time as Alby Hans Freedman aka Norman Greene. They shared the same cell for several years and it was Freedman who became Sydcombe’s protector. Apparently, the guy was the runt of his family and couldn’t fight his way out of a wet paper bag...now why would someone like Al Freedman become the man’s protector? Mmm...” She glanced at me wanting an answer. I didn’t have a clue. She shook her head before continuing. “The Sydcombe family is well known around the New England area and has a large property north-east of Guyra and another which is owned and managed by old man Sydcombe further into the high country and closer to Armidale...the smaller property near Guyra is managed by Harry-boy Sydcombe and has been since the guy was released from prison after serving his six-month parole period...a large family by all accounts

with most not in favour of permitting Harry-boy to manage the smaller property closer to Guyra...he has surprised everyone by doing a marvellous job. Settled down. Married and now has a tribe of kids. The property paying for itself with a profit for the past ten years. Harry-boy successfully completed an on-line Agricultural and Farm Accountancy Degree...with Honours! The old man was correct in his wisdom...worth a visit, don't you reckon?"

I nodded.

"How do you know all that?" I was bamboozled.

"Wikipedia. Face Book and a separate family site that was a mine of information. People do not seem to realise all this stuff is available to the world once they have placed it on Facebook even if they have security hooks...they are easy to get around if you know how."

"...and if anyone is interested..." I quickly responded.

"Yeah...I guess. Like a snoopy computer-savvy computer detective like me!" Angie beamed.

I slowly shook my head wondering not for the first time what I would do without her.

"You were wondering..." I began. A smirk to go with the query.

“Yes...remember the time not long ago when you thought football goal sizes were too large?”

“Arrh...all right. I will bite. So?”

“You do realise that those goals you see each night on the daily News are just the highlights, don’t you?”

“Well...yes. I guess...”

“You didn’t, did you? In a soccer...a football match, they could play the entire two halves without ever going near the goal mouth...a bloody boring result if you ask me...” She glanced over at me. I wasn’t too sure what she was getting at. I still thought they should decrease the size of the goal mouth to give the goalie a better chance of defending his position...but I wasn’t about to get into an argument with her...

We were silent as we headed towards the M1 to head south towards Sydney.

“Yes...what the heck. We have an overnight bag each. I’ll ring the Boss for approvals to extend our time away from the office and head up north-west towards Guyra...” I leant forward to compute in our destination into the GPS thing. I exhaled deeply and leant back in my seat. I saw Angie smiling out of the corner of my eye.

“I am not going to say a bloody thing, Methuselah...not a thing. We just follow the Motorway north and cut across using Waterfall Way to come out north of Guyra and south of Armidale...easy as!” Stated in a very patronising manner.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

I telephoned ahead to discuss our plans and reasons for wanting to be in the area with the local Sergeant of the small Guyra Police Station. We popped into the Station to go over tactics, share information and intelligence as to why we were in the district and to get the feel of the lie of the land.

A call came in taken by the Sergeant who silenced us with a wave of his hand.

“Dan? That’s good...you’re sure it was the vehicle in question? A fawn Toyota Troopie banged about a bit with a roof-top tent and all the bells and whistles? Wide wheels with a suspension ‘lift’? Fair ‘nuff. The driver? You are sure it is our man... Alby Hans Freedman. Yep...”

The Sergeant turned to me as he ended the call.

“Um...Dan Samuels...a mate of Harry-boy Sydcombe since the man took over the running of the lower property around fifteen...closer to twenty years ago...it is closer to town and surprise, surprise he went at it like a duck to water. Amazed all of us...old man Harry Sydcombe took a risk on his son, and it paid off heaps...the chap who sighted our wanted man is the Captain of the Volunteer Bushfire Brigade. They received that flyer you sent off. Recognised Freedman straight away when he was flagged down on the Warra back road...he was a little nervous being so close to a wanted murderer, but he was also interested in what the man wanted. Seems he wanted the quickest route to the Harry-boy property which he understood was hereabouts. My guess he wants a favour returned...to be hidden away somewhere on the property until the heat wears off. I doubt he realises how close we are to him. My advice? We get out to Harry-boy's farm as quick as possible...Freedman has shown he has a quick temper and when he is riled, he resorts to gunfire. Harry-boy has a wife and seven kids at last count...and a farmhand and his missus and two kids also on the farm...we will ensure they will barricade themselves into the farmhouse...part of the original farmhouse was built of stone, but it has been extended several times as the family increased. They will remain in the house until we arrive. Harry-boy has few long guns...he is not a gun fan...”

We spent the next two hours organising additional police from Armidale...and a Chopper to do ground and radar sweeps of the area...and after a phone conversation with Harry-boy, the most likely spot for Freedman to hunker down was in a back paddock near a cattle yard and loading ramp. Running water nearby. The dirt track followed the boundary fenceline of the Harry-boy Sydcombe farming property and then disappeared into the State forest that the property backed onto. There was a thick grove of trees that could provide the necessary cover from the air...but not heat penetrating radar that this chopper was equipped with. Orders were relayed with the map coordinates given to the pilot as we, in a four 4WD convoy sped towards the property.

We had been ordered...ordered to leave our Unmarked at the Police Station as it would not survive the rough track conditions and several creek crossings that had been damaged during late winter storms of this year.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

To say the fifty-odd kilometre ride to the Harry-boy Sydcombe farm was a bumpy one was an understatement in the extreme! I would like to see the monthly mechanic's bill to repair/replace damaged

suspension systems on their large 4WD fleet of four! While I thought we were travelling way too fast for the road conditions, it took us close to two hours to arrive at the Warrabarronga Station homestead.

We could not hazard a guess on when or how our suspect might confront his former cellmate, but we felt sure waiting patiently for his appearance was a far better tactic than trying to storm Freedman's present position. That was the way people got hurt...and killed according to Sergeant Stan Tiller who was in-charge of all Uniformed Coppers on-site. His approach was more softly, softly...with patience the go...the circling of the copper chopper would eventually cause the blood pressure of our quarry to rise...and that is when things unexpectedly occurred going on the history of the man...it would flush the man out of his 'nest.'

It was getting close to dinnertime with the children becoming restless. The two families were huddled together in the large Bathroom in the original side of the farmhouse made of stone quarried on the farm. The door locked with towels over the two narrow windows. All lights of the sprawling farmhouse off with the coppers patrolling the perimeter relying on the bright moonlight. Both Uniform and Plainclothes coppers had long-guns resting in their arms. Waiting patiently for something to happen...or not.

A far-off vehicle horn could be heard getting louder as the 4WD got closer to the sprawling homestead.

In a cloud of dust and all lights blazing, the Troopie came to a sudden stop at the gate into the homestead yard. Around twenty metres from the front of the homestead's veranda line. Freedman alighted immersed in that cloud of dust, emerging to stand silhouetted by the high beam and driving lights that were all illuminated on his truck. He stood in front of his vehicle. A rifle pointed at the front door of the farmhouse.

“Harry-boy!” The man roared, standing at the threshold of the house gate. “You owes me big time since we shared a cell in the Big House plenty of years ago. Instead of granting me a return favour you bastard, you sold me out to the fuckin’ coppers. Come out...yer dog to get what yer deserve, yer cringin’ cur!”

“Lower that rifle, mate. Gently and slowly place it on the ground beside you...” Sergeant Tiller instructed in a gentle, calm voice.

Freedman took several deep breaths. Spread his feet further apart as though he was readying himself to spin in the direction of the voice.

“And if I don’t, copper?” A sneer in the voice. It was obvious the man did not like coppers.

“This here is my elephant gun. Haven’t used it much lately so it needs to have a couple of shells fired through it to stop it from getting rusty...” The Sergeant replied slowly. “It will blow a bloody great hole in your chest that a Mack truck can drive through, hear me, mate?” Again, in that calm, slow cadence.

When we had first heard a vehicle horn, and the house dogs had begun to bark in unison, the Sergeant and his 2IC had slipped out the back door of the large house to run to the side of his 4WD that was parked at the front corner of the house fence. He was now leaning over the hood of the vehicle, his elbow firmly resting on the flat metal surface, his body in a classic pose of a shooter. His eye looking steadily over the sights at the figure before him. His Senior Constable leant against the rear of the same vehicle, a rifle aimed and ready. A layer of dust wiped clean off the rear of the truck onto the uniform of the copper.

Freedman again exhaled, lowering his blood pressure and anger...

“Yer old mate did not sell you out to us coppers. We knew you were in the area as the Captain of the Volunteer Bushfire Brigade recognised you...you flagged him down asking directions to Harry-boy Sydcombe’s farm...remember? He rang us. Hear me. Harry-boy did not snitch on yer...we did our homework

discovering that you and Harry-boy in there..." Jutting his chin in the direction of the homestead. "You were cellmates for a couple of years, and you were his protector against those who thought that Harry-boy was worth a bum-fuck. You protected him...I cannot understand why as it seems to go against your character, don't you think? We figured that you would head this way looking for a favour that you think Harry-boy owed you...am I right so far. We added one and one and here we are. Now...slowly place yer rifle on the ground beside yer with the safety on, otherwise you will be wearing that bloody big hole very shortly... I am running out of patience and even though there have been too many bodies lying about with your signature on them, another don't make much difference to me...hear me, mate? I've shot bigger men than you with this rifle and it sure leaves a bloody mess...and besides, my off-sider is at the rear of this truck with a similar rifle pointing at yer head...so's yer got double chances of a quick death...now...do as I ask, Freedman. Nice and slow..."

Freedman stood stock still, possibly thinking over his alternatives and what his life maybe worth with three homicide killings hanging over his head. Like so many killers before him though, he was afraid to die...

He slowly placed his long gun on the ground beside him as instructed. Stood and turned to face his vehicle

as three Constables briefly wrestled with the man before slipping the handcuffs onto his wrists...it was over...everyone sighed a huge sigh of relief and even the tribe of kids could feel the anxiety levels drop...

The man was manacled with his legs tied to a shackle in the rear seat of one of the 4WDs. The family were told multiple times that the danger was over, and they would never have trouble from this crim again...it still took some time to reassure all the kids that the danger was over...

CHAPTER NINETEEN

It took ten working days to have Alby Hans 'Al' Freedman aka Norman Greene transferred from the New England jurisdiction where he was arrested and charged to our offices at Parramatta.

He was sitting patiently in front of Angie and I in Number Two Interview Room. The Boss was in the adjacent Electronic Equipment Room watching proceedings. Two Dees with him along with the Electronics Officer manning the equipment. We had a multiple killer in our midst which was against the norm, and thank God, totally unusual!

“You killed ‘Pug’ Pugowski on or about the seventh of June. Your vehicle was seen...and video-recorded entering the New Holland Park from New Holland Parade on that night at around ten in the evening. Half-an-hour later it was seen exiting that same park...”

“That don’t mean I was driving me Troopie. I could have lent it to someone overnight perhaps...it’s been too long ago now to remember stuff like that...” Freedman suggested softly, his head bowed.

I nodded, expecting that ‘come back.’ I spun a grainy photo across the table toward him.

“Is that you?” I asked pointedly. The photograph a black and white ‘zoom’ shot of the vehicle as it exited the Park. Yes, it was grainy, but the person was still identifiable mainly because of the snow-white stubble beard that was still there...he would have to have a ‘Number One or Two’ trim every now and then. Vanity reigned I thought with the process as fiddly as regular shaving!

“Mmm...yeah...well...it ain’t a good reproduction... very grainy...hard to tell...” He looked hard at the twenty-five by twenty photo size. Perhaps a grin beginning but quickly, it disappeared.

I did not expect him to agree that the figure driving the 4WD...which was unmistakably his vehicle...was him

but I felt his physical reaction while looking at the photograph was as sufficient as a verbal confession!

“There were three muzzle flashes which resulted in a small shot pattern centred on the victim’s chest. That killed him instantly. You rolled him into the nearby open drain where he was washed approximately two hundred and thirty metres downstream by a sudden rainstorm around thirty minutes after your egress from the park on that night...do you remember the incident?”

“What’s egress?” He asked, wanting to slow the interview speed down. I ignored his meagre attempt.

“You were arrested, charged and sentenced to twenty years for the homicide murder of that young shop assistant Aimee Plenty as she alighted from her vehicle to begin her afternoon shift in one of the nearby shops in the Parramatta Shopping Centre...the pattern of slugs to her chest were similar to those you inflicted on your latest victim...Pugowski...”

“Man...c’mon!” An instance of anger flashed across his face. “Man...I served my time for that little affair and have been clean for just on twenty years since being released from the Big House...”

I could hardly hide the smile that the remark caused...a *‘little affair’* was putting it mildly.

“The same pattern of shots.” I continued. “You like to face your quarry...eye to eye...toe to toe before shooting the person at close range. Three quick shots one after the other. Bam, bam, bam! Why were you at the New Holland Park at that time of night if not to shoot Pugowski?”

He ignored the question, turning his head away from me. Drumming his fingers on the tabletop as a sign of complete disinterest.

“What was your reason for shooting him?” Again, he ignored my question, continuing to drum his fingers on the tabletop. He was hoping to get under my skin.

It would never succeed!

“The handgun that was found under the pillow on your side of the matrimonial bed that you shared with Sandra Cecelia Worthington several weeks ago was used to kill that young shop assistant as used to shoot dead Pugowski in the same manner...why? What had the man ever done to you? You do not walk with a limp like so many of *his* victims.”

He looked at me before looking away, again with an air of total indifference.

“Did he try to smash your knee...that was his calling card in the yard, wasn’t it? In the Pen...where were you

together?”

Multiple questions I scolded myself, were not a good interrogation technique. ‘*Tighten it up man*’ I thought to myself.

He nodded. Shifted in the chair that was bolted to the floor. Glancing at Angie’s chest to keep his attention span away from my questions.

“Remand...for a couple of weeks...” He eventually offered coolly. “One thing you learn quick is who is the top dog in the yard...and you don’t challenge him...” He thought he was revealing a pearl...

He was talking though...that was a start!

“Yeah...but you challenged him for the top dog spot, huh?” An educated guess on my part.

“Yer gotta...yer gotta show yer creds to the other inmates...yer know...assert your authority otherwise theys are all over you! Isn’t that what youse coppers say?”

“You challenged him...but you haven’t a bunged-up knee...” A statement more than a question.

“Nah...ha! I was quicker’n he thought I was...missed my knee by a hen’s breath falling flat on his back. All the phlebs who saw it gasped as Pugowski had never

been on his back before..." A certain degree of boastfulness in his mien. "I was about to squash his balls with a decent stomp of me foot when he bashed the flat of his gym-shoe straight into me face. Smashed me nose to pieces. Took out three of me top teeth and fractured me upper gum. Took two lower teeth and fractured me lower jaw. He smiled...the bloody nerve of him. He smiled. He was a lot faster than what I thought he was..." He lightly ran his fingers around his mouth and both cheeks as though there was still pain if felt too hard...

"You were in hospital for some time..." I encouraged him to continue.

"Yeah...theys weren't that interested in fixing me face and mouth up. Gave me false teeth that have never fitted properly. Continuous pain having trouble breathing through me nose..."

"Pugowski?"

"Yeah...when I got back into the clink again, Pug was well and truly gone...don't know where...looked for him for a lot of years before hooking up with him in that park...had fooled him about a ready supply of painkillers...shot him...he had caused me pain for all me life..."

“You shot him in the chest...a cluster of three in a small pattern. Just as you had done to that young Shop Assistant that you did twenty years for...the same M.O. Rolled him into the open storm drain and forgot about him...you just drove away. What did he need the painkillers for?”

“Some phleb got the drop on him. Pushed a shiv straight into the back of his knee when he was in Parkleigh Prison so’s I was told a ways back...payback time I reckon...it slowed him down so’s I was told.” He paused looking down at his hands. Smiled to himself before looking up at me. “I...arrh...I had an op’ration to try and fix me pain and breathing problems. At John Hunter Hospital...it was close by so’s me missus could come and visit...a Specialist who should have knowed what he was doing...the op’ration done no good. I’s still get painful headaches and shooting pains up me nose. The op’ration was botched...he should have knowed better. He won’t botch another op’ration that’s for sure...” He looked away, a slight smirk giving me the creeps as though he was pleased with the outcome. I was surprised he had just confessed to the murder of the Surgeon...

I held up my biro, looking up at the camera lens.

“Time for a break, don’t you think?” Angie asked the man taking the cue from my reactions. “We’ve been at

it for over three hours. We will have you escorted back to the cells. You can have a break of say a couple of hours. Have a nap, eh?" She suggested.

Freedman nodded, as he was feeling as tired as me...

CHAPTER TWENTY

"Anything?" Angie asked the Boss as we walked into the Electronics Room.

"Um...hang on...you're a bit too premature...um...the Specialist would be an ENT Surgeon..." the Boss countered.

"Or a Plastic Surgeon." Angie added.

"Not so fast Angie..." The Boss complained, getting a little chuffed...

"Look up both Norman Greene and Alby Hans 'Al' Freedman as patients at the hospital. He used both interchangeably whatever took his fancy...he has the correct plastic for both names." I offered quietly. I was ready for an afternoon nap. The morning interview techniques draining more stamina from me than I now seemed to have...

“Yeah...yeah...okay. Not so fast...a well-respected ENT Specialist and Surgeon was run over and killed as he ended his shift around twenty-two-hundred hours. No witnesses...nothing has advanced on the case except the wounds suffered by the man would indicate a bullbar being the culprit...therefore more than likely a 4WD was involved...nothing more...”

“Was that around the time of Freedman’s nose operation?” Angie asked.

I was out of the loop, having seated myself at a corner desk slipping in and out of a fugue state.

“Um...” The Boss’s two finger typing manner was slow. I could feel Angie’s rising impatience wanting to shift the Boss from in front of the computer screen and keyboard and take over...she was a whizz when it came to speed-typing. “Um...” The Boss continued. “Um...no...the operation was some fifteen months prior to the Surgeon’s death...not related...too far apart...”

“Don’t sell out our bloke so cheaply...” I murmured from my corner position. “He took over eight years to eventually track down Pugowski and kill him. He has nothing but patience when he is on the hunt.” I added.

“Mmm...” The Boss sat back in the comfortable seat. “That don’t mean a thing...yeah, sure...we could surmise the connection, but he did not confess to the

crime...only knowing about the death. I doubt we could bring this to a successful conclusion. The Defence would have a field day with it when it got to Court. No...we cannot continue with this homicide as it is based on the emotional content of all of us. Not enough to get a conviction...sorry people, but that is the facts!"

I sighed deeply. It would have rounded out the case against the man nicely...but them's the breaks, I guess.

Some you win; some you lose...

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

After enjoying a sleep that involved only two incidents of voiding my bladder, I felt rejuvenated and enthusiastic to proceed. It had been a while since I had such a pleasant night's sleep without too many interruptions. Staggering to the toilet half asleep was usually a nightly habit every two hours...my GP saying all elderly men suffered the same nightly routine!

This morning though, I felt great!

Angie and I sat opposite Al Freedman wanting to complete what questions we still had. We both had Iced Coffees and we had shouted Freedman a Coke! This was an action that was always frowned upon. We

compromised having cold drinks instead of our usual steaming hot coffees which would never do being so close to a guy who you were never too sure which way and how he would react holding a hot coffee.

We proceeded through the pleasantries to relax all of us...how had he spent the night? Was the evening and morning meals up to scratch? Stuff like that to get into a tempo...a speed which helped with answers coming fast at times...as though the crim wanted to retain the tempo.

“How did you feel about Doctor Peter Jenkins death?” I began, surprising both Angie who glanced over at me and every member sitting in the Electronics Room watching proceedings.

“What the fuck is he doing?” The Boss exploded. “He has gone completely off the script that we discussed this morning...not more than an hour ago! Bloody hell!”

I continued with my own script that had materialised in my mind during the night. Emerging only after the morning's meeting to discuss tactics...which I had partially disagreed with. I felt sure we needed to get him on that roller-coaster ride of emotions again as we had yesterday afternoon.

“I mean, he fucked up big time with the operation he performed on you. I am guessing you suffer more pain now than before the procedure, huh?”

A shrug. A disinterested look but his heartbeat went up to dangerous levels. His face changing colour to that of a badly sunburnt person. He had begun that rollercoaster ride of yesterday.

“Did you shoot him the same as the young Aimee Plenty for which you received twenty years with a non-parole period of only three months because you could not control your temper ...or the need to kill in a certain way...how did you feel?” I felt I had him on the verge of exploding...you could see his blood pressure going through the roof...it was an easy thing to do. Countless sessions in anger management control while in prison had done little for him...he was still that dangerous pressure cooker person walking about...

He twitched. A blood vessel in his forehead appeared. Another in his neck wanted to burst! Leaning towards me...staring at me...he again thumped the table with the side of his fist.

“Bloody hell! No! I ran over the bastard and kept on going...” He exploded, too late trying to shut himself up.

“A hit and run incident where you deliberately ran over him...apparently the bullbar on your 4WD caused massive injuries...did that make you feel better for the botched operation he performed on you?” I wanted to ensure that blood pressure remained high!

“Too bloody right. He got everything he deserved...”
Still red in the face.

“It was well-planned. You scoped out the area and where security cameras were and where they weren’t, huh?”

“Too bloody right...yer gotta plan for these things. If’n there was one thing I learnt when I was in the clink doing those Anger Management Courses...too bloody many of them...is yer gotta control what yer are doing...” He was chilling way too early. Coming down off the high. I had to get him angry again. I spun a photo of his beloved 4WD across to him.

“All the bells and whistles, eh?”

“Too bloody right! Yer gotta be prepared...” He looked longingly at the photo as though it was a Rolls Royce... or an E-type Jag!

The Boss had retaken his seat in the Electronic Room, his blood pressure slowly abating...which for him was a good thing as he was a heart attack waiting to happen.

“It is still an early model Toyota Troopie worth squat! A nineteen-eighty-three model worth squat! Pretty banged up as well which would have a huge effect on its value...worth squat!” My voice rising again.

“Not to me...” He answered defensively, his blood pressure increasing. His nostrils flaring. Some-one was mocking his pride and joy. That was *not* on!

“Yer can’t get away from it...yer spent thousands of dollars on the thing and it still is an early model Troopie worth squat...a total waste of money...”

He slammed the edge of his fist onto the stainless-steel topped table with some force.

“Not to me it ain’t!!” He screamed on the verge of standing. The chains holding him down preventing the action which made him angrier.

“She stopped giving you money to pour into the piece of shit...that why you killed her!?” I yelled louder. “... and then you killed the dog, you AO...killed a poor little fluffy dog...” Allowing the anger to pass. Slowly dissipating. I was playing him as an Angler would play a fish.

“Yeah...” He replied sadly. “The dog...” He looked dejectedly across at me. Nodded his head. Looked

down at the tabletop. “She didn’t give me a cent for the truck. It was all my money...”

“Cash...quite a bit...where did you get money like that?”

“I...” He paused, suddenly realising he had almost put himself in.

“Drug money...” I replied for him. “You were involved in the procurement and selling on of painkillers to people in need...who were hooked on a steady supply of the pills...a lucrative business selling what most people would see the Doctor about...” I paused wanting him to understand the illegality of the business. “So why did you kill your missus if it wasn’t over money?” I asked quietly. He was going down for multiple murders, so a little drug procurement and on-selling was a sidebar to the bigger picture, so I let it pass...the DPP Rep would determine if the matter should be mentioned in Court.

“She aren’t my missus...” He bowed his head and slowly shook it. “We never got married. I paid her rent to live in her house...”

“So why kill her?” I again asked softly.

“So’s she wouldn’t tell lies about me...” Said so matter-of-factly as though it was a given...I did not

comprehend the content of his statement...

“Like what?” I asked, spreading my arms akimbo in a questioning manner.

He shrugged.

“I don’t know. It weren’t my lies...it was hers...so I don’t know...she’d tell people...but they’d be all bullshit! A pack of lies...”

There you go.

We had a confession for the three homicide murders from him...taped and videoed.

I sat back away from the man feeling depleted. Not pleased at the outcome...just emotionally drained. I wanted to be as far away as possible from the AO...I looked at the man...a poor example of a regular male. I wondered what had happened during his formative years to turn him into a monster. Human nature never failed to amaze me. The longer I lived, the more surprised I became at what humans could do to another for such puny reasons.

“...and the dog...” I almost whispered leaning back towards him.

“Yeah...well...” Tears welled in his eyes. The only time he came close to crying. “I couldn’t leave her to die of

hunger and thirst...”

I almost collapsed after he was escorted by the Uniformed Constables from the small Interview Room to be taken down to the sub-basement cells for the rest of the afternoon and overnight. He would be up for the Bail Hearing sometime tomorrow where we would object to Bail being granted.

I was ultra-exhausted from the rollercoaster ride of emotions that I had raised. I wanted to go home... which I did not long after we clapped hands, shoulder-nudged and listened to the praise heaped upon me.

“You were like a Trout angler teasing, teasing the quarry. Like...I’ve never seen a cleverer interrogation like that before...” The Boss praised me. I nodded my thanks as I suggested to Angie that we share a coffee and she a bite to eat. I wasn’t hungry...I just wanted to relax...to get away from the stuffy, small room before I headed home...

The following morning...late... I found that Angie had cleared up the interrogation with members of the DPP being present. The multiple homicides were being prepared for Court proceedings without my input...who needs me...like a hand plunged into a bucket of water, when that hand is removed, there were no signs of its immersion noticeable...though my hand would feel wet!

I wondered whether retirement would be like that. The steamroller of justice would just keep on rolling on without me...yep...it would!

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

There was still a chill in the air though Spring had arrived according to the Calendar!

I gazed up the length of the Manly Promenade then down along the sandy extent of the beach. There were no sounds of crashing surf, the water a mirror smooth surface. More people walking...strolling about on the promenade or at the water's edge...

"Amazing, isn't it." Angie commented. "The Pacific Ocean is the largest body of water on this planet yet there isn't a murmur...a trace of movement..."

"Yeah...that's why it was called the Pacific. Mother Nature and one of her many moods just like every woman..." I murmured in reply, waiting for an irate response.

"Now...that Detective Joseph Lind, is sexist..." She admonished.

“I thought it more poetic...” I replied, a smirk to suggest I had ‘got’ her.

She chuckled knowing she had been caught.

“The last time we were here, my senior partner, you began to tell me a story...”

“Yeah!? I don’t recall...” I responded. “What was it about?”

“One of your shortest reminiscences, so you informed me. Not long enough to fill out five pages let alone novel length was your complaint. What I am saying is that these short stories of yours will accelerate your want...your enthusiasm to type longer and longer stories. Tales that you have experienced in your lengthy career...”

“Yeah, yeah! Oh!? What was it about?” I was now beginning to become interested though for the life of me I could not recall the story I had begun...

“Um...let’s get an ice-cream first, eh?”

“A good suggestion. Your shout as it is your idea.”

By the time we returned to our perch it had been taken by an elderly couple taking their ‘Doodle’ or whatever type of ‘doodle’ it was for its daily walk. We strolled

further down the promenade towards the main South Manly Beach licking our ice-creams.

“Seats are at a premium by the looks of it. The first hints of summer and people crawl out of their cosy retreats.” I observed. “We can sit on the seawall. The stone capping is wide enough to sit...quite comfortable actually...it’s the getting up that could be a problem!” I mused as I paused to sit down, swinging my legs over to look at the water.

“Hah!” Angie laughed as she sank down to sit on the wide stone capping beside me. “You and...I forget who your partner was at the time. You were in the Upper Hunter Valley conducting a lesson on how to conduct security and other duties around a murder scene without stuffing up DNA evidence by plodding through with their size fourteens...”

“Yeah...that’s right. Yeah...now I remember...um...I forget the cop shop we were at...somewhere in the Upper Hunter Valley when a call came through to the Sergeant of shots fired. The guy...the family were well-known to the local guys as they made regular visits to the farmhouse. As me and...Shelley...I think it was Shelley Shields...we were the senior coppers, so etiquette required that we be invited along. There were only two cop vehicles...both 4WDs. We stopped on the road and walked up the farm track on a slight incline to

the farmhouse. The bloke looked as though he was asleep holding a single barrel big-bore shotgun across his thighs. He was sitting in a ratty sofa lounge that had seen better days. I felt terribly naked as all I had was my Force issue Glock handgun. I was sure Shelley felt the same...peashooters against a big-bore shotgun. The other coppers came well-prepared with powerful long guns. We crept closer to the farmhouse not wanting to make a noise..." I finished off my ice-cream. "Um... suddenly the bloke stirred, lifted the shotgun towards his head with it going off prematurely so I have always believed. We will never know if it was deliberate or an accident, but the shot took the back of the bloke's skull straight off as though it had occurred in an operating room conducted by a competent surgeon. Some of the pellets ricocheted into his brain and are still lodged there..." I shook my head at the memory. "He wears a steel cap over that area...you know, like those skull caps Jewish men wear but his is some type of metal... and he always wears a bike helmet over that. He was in hospital for months...over a year and when he was well enough to appear before the Court, we were summoned as the senior coppers on-site at the time, to attend. The Magistrate listened patiently to both the Prosecution and Defence arguments while glancing at the defendant seated in an electric wheelchair oblivious to proceedings. A Court-appointed Psychiatrist gave evidence and after an adjournment of two days we were called back into the Courtroom. The magistrate was

quite blunt and dismissed all charges against the defendant saying he did not understand, comprehend, or consider culpability for the shooting of his wife, two kids and the house dog with the large-bore shotgun...in fact he was ignorant of their deaths or he being guilty of the crime...a terrible scene let me tell you. She stated that the defendant now existed in a prison partially of his own doing from which escape will be impossible... a prison from which escape will be impossible...so sad. There was not a dry eye in that Courtroom on that morning...and I will never forget those words...”

pcb

01/02/2026